MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (Honours)/ MGU-BBA (Honours)/ MGU-BCA (Honours)

REGULAR EXAMINATION October 2026

Fifth SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG5DSEPOL301 - SOCIETY AND POLITICS IN KERALA

Part A One Word Answer all questions Each question carries 1 marks

1. Brahmaswam

2. Sree Moolam Popular Assembly

3. The southern parts of Travancore, particularly the four taluks of Agastheeswaram, Thovalai, Kalkulam and Vilavancode, were transferred to Madras State

4. Remittances are money sent by people working away from their home region or country to their families or communities back home.

5. Christians

6. Ayyankali.

7. Channar (Nadar) community.

8. Nairs, Ezhavas, Christians, and Muslims, along with other sections of society.

9. Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, Queer/Questioning, and other sexual orientations and gender identities

10. Maharaja Chithira Thirunal Balarama Varma of Travancore. **[1x10 = 10]**

Part BShort Answer QuestionsAnswer any 6 questionsEach question carries 5 marks

11. The Kundara Proclamation of 1809 was issued by Velu Thampi Dalawa, the Diwan of Travancore, against British interference in the affairs of the state.Causes:- British interference in Travancore's administration and internal affairs- Opposition to the growing political dominance of the East India Company- Economic pressure caused by financial obligations and the Subsidiary Alliance- Conflict between Velu Thampi and the British Resident, Colonel Macaulay- Desire to defend the sovereignty and independence of Travancore.Historical significance:- called upon the people to unite against British authority- mobilised sections of society against colonial domination- became an important episode in the early anti-colonial resistance in Kerala- demonstrated the conflict between indigenous political authority and British imperial expansion.

12. The Malayali Memorial, submitted to the Maharaja of Travancore in 1891, was a petition demanding greater opportunities for educated Malayalis in government employment.Its major demands were- Adequate representation of native Malayalis in government services-

Reduction of the dominance of non-Malayali Brahmins, particularly Tamil Brahmins, in administrative positions- Equal employment opportunities for qualified Malayalis- Recognition of the educational qualifications and abilities of local candidates- Fairness and justice in public appointments.The memorial was signed by prominent individuals, including K. P. Sankara Menon and Dr. Palpu, and received broad support from educated sections of society. It marked an important stage in the development of political consciousness, organised public action and demands for administrative representation in Travancore.

13. Coalition governments are administrations formed by two or more political parties that cooperate to secure a legislative majority. Major features - Bipolar political competition- multi-party participation- Power sharing- Common programmes- Negotiation and compromise- Role of smaller parties- Electoral accountability. Coalition politics has encouraged pluralistic representation in Kerala, although it can also create disagreements over leadership, policies and the distribution of power.

14. Land reforms were important in transforming Kerala's agrarian society by weakening traditional landlordism and improving the position of cultivating tenants. Contributions: - Abolition of tenancy exploitation- Security of tenure- Ownership rights- Reduction of social inequality- Social empowerment- Rural transformation- Democratic participation. Landlessness persisted among many agricultural labourers, particularly Dalit and Adivasi communities, and the reforms did not eliminate all rural inequalities.Therefore, land reforms were a major component of Kerala's social transformation, though their benefits were unevenly distributed.

15. V. T. Bhattathiripad was a prominent social reformer who challenged conservative practices within Namboodiri Brahmin society.Hecriticised:- Eldest-son marriage privilege- Restrictions on women's freedom- Child marriage- Restrictions on widow remarriage- Lack of women's education- Caste hierarchy- Conservative customs. Through his writings, theatre and reform activities, especially the play AdukkalayilNinnuArangathekkuhe advocated women's emancipation and social reform.His contribution was significant in the development of progressive thought within Kerala's Namboodiri community.

16. Before European colonisation, Kerala had a flourishing agricultural and maritime commercial economy. Majorfeatures: - Agricultural production- Spice cultivation -Maritime trade- Port towns- Merchant communities- Agrarian social structure

- Regional and international exchange. Kerala's precolonial economy combined agriculture, local markets and international maritime trade, laying the foundation for its later commercial development.

17. ChattampiSwamikal was a major social and religious reformer who challenged caste-based restrictions on learning and spiritual knowledge in Kerala.His main contributions included: - Criticism of Brahminical supremacy- Democratisation of knowledge- Scriptural reinterpretation- Opposition to caste discrimination- Promotion of rational inquiry- Influence on social reform.

18. The Kerala Education Bill was introduced by the first elected Communist government of Kerala, led by E. M. S. Namboodiripad, in 1957. Education Minister Joseph Mundassery played a major role in its formulation.Majorprovisions:- Regulation of private schools- Teachers' service conditions- Salary protection- Appointment procedures- Educational standards- Government supervision- Protection of teachers. The Bill generated strong opposition from sections of private school managements and religious organisations, contributing to the VimochanaSamaram (Liberation Struggle) of 1958–59.

19.Endosulfan is a toxic organochlorine pesticide that was aerially sprayed over cashew plantations in Kasaragod district, Kerala, for several years. Its use became the centre of a major public health and environmental controversy.Public health consequences:- Neurological problems: Exposed populations reported neurological disorders, including seizures and developmental difficulties.- Congenital abnormalities: Some affected families reported birth defects and developmental abnormalities.- Reproductive health concerns: Reports included reproductive difficulties and other health problems.- Developmental disorders: Children in affected areas experienced developmental delays and disabilities.- Long-term health concerns: Persistent pesticide contamination raised concerns about prolonged exposure through the environment.- Psychological and economic hardship: Affected families faced emotional distress, medical expenses and caregiving burdens.- Environmental contamination: Concerns arose over contamination of soil, water and local ecosystems.The Endosulfan controversy led to public protests, demands for medical support and compensation, and restrictions on the pesticide. Kerala prohibited its use, and India subsequently banned it nationally in 2011.

20. The growth of peasant and working-class politics has played a major role in Kerala's social, economic and political development. significance:-- Workers' rights- Agrarian reforms- Social justice- Political participation- Welfare policies- Collective bargaining- Contemporary challenges- Democratic accountability. **[5x6 = 30]**

Part CEssay QuestionsAnswer any 2 questionsEach question carries 15 marks

21. Thrippadidanam was a significant political and religious act performed by Marthanda Varma in 1750, when he dedicated the Kingdom of Travancore to Lord Padmanabha of Sree Padmanabhaswamy Temple, Thiruvananthapuram.Thrippadidanam also served as a powerful political instrument to legitimize royal authority, weaken rival power centres and consolidate Travancore into a centralized monarchy- Before Marthanda Varma, Travancore was characterized by the influence of powerful nobles, local chieftains and regional power holders.- The EttuveetilPillamar, a group of eight influential noble families, traditionally exercised considerable political and economic influence.- Marthanda Varma adopted military and administrative measures to suppress the political influence of the EttuveetilPillamar and other opponents.- Thrippadidanam strengthened this process by providing a religious and ideological justification for the king's authority- The concept of Padmanabha Dasa gave his rule a distinctive religious legitimacy- Thrippadidanam symbolically placed the entire kingdom under the sovereignty of Lord Padmanabha, represented by the monarch.- It reinforced the idea of a unified kingdom rather than a collection of territories controlled by competing feudal authorities.- Marthanda Varma expanded royal control over administration,

revenue collection and military organization- The influence of local chieftains and hereditary elites was reduced as the central government became more powerful- These developments helped transform Travancore from a fragmented political order into a more centralized state- The temple became a major symbol of Travancore's political identity and royal legitimacy- Thus, it combined religious devotion with practical state-building.

22. Poykayil Sree Kumara Gurudevan was a prominent Dalit social reformer, poet and anti-caste thinker in Kerala. He founded the Prathyaksha Raksha Daiva Sabha (PRDS) in 1909 to challenge caste discrimination and promote the dignity of oppressed communities. Through his songs and narrations of slavery, he highlighted the historical suffering, exploitation and social exclusion of Dalits in Kerala. Narrations of slavery as an alternative historical source- PoykayilAppachan questioned conventional histories that neglected the experiences of enslaved and oppressed communities. Exposure of the institution of slavery- His narrations highlighted the existence of slavery in Kerala is subjected to caste-based exploitation- Social discrimination and untouchability- Economic exploitation and landlessness- Recovery of Dalit memory and identity- Critique of mainstream historiography- Resistance and social emancipation- Historical significance and limitations-- His narrations provide valuable insights into the experiences and collective memories of oppressed communities. His works represent both a critique of caste society and an important contribution to Dalit-centred historiography.

23. Coalition politics refers to a political arrangement in which two or more political parties come together to form a government or contest elections by sharing power and responsibilities. Advantages of Coalition Politics in Kerala- Representation of diverse interests- Strengthening of democracy- Political stability through established fronts- Protection of minority interests- Promotion of consensus-based decision-making- Continuity of welfare policies- Decentralisation of political power.Disadvantages- Political instability- Compromise on ideological principles- Excessive bargaining by smaller parties- Delay in decision-making- Compromise in policy implementation- Opportunistic alliances- Increased political competition and factionalism- Limited accountability.

24. Kerala's land reforms are considered an important achievement in India's social and economic history. The Kerala Agrarian Relations Act, 1960, and the Kerala Land Reforms Act, 1963, as amended in 1969, aimed to abolish tenancy, protect tenants and impose ceilings on landholdings. These reforms weakened the traditional landlord system and improved the social position of many agricultural tenants. -Achievements of land reforms-- Abolition of tenancy- Reduction of landlord power - Social transformation - Political empowerment- Improved living conditions. Limitations - Exclusion of agricultural labourers- Limited redistribution- Continuing economic dependence - Historical caste inequalities- Unequal distribution of benefits- Limitations concerning Adivasi communities-- Traditional land alienation- Failure to recognise customary rights, their ancestral territories and forest resources- Displacement and migration- Weak implementation of restoration measures- Continuing land struggles. Kerala's land reforms achieved significant agrarian and social transformation, but their benefits were unevenly distributed across caste and tribal communities. **[15x2 = 30]**